> Organizations that put effort into using data to improve their understanding of their customers demonstrate a higher return on data investments.

With this focal point in place, they begin to think about how to align their business processes to reflect this value statement. Policies are the best tools to shape business processes at any governance body's disposal, so let's see how they work in practice.

3.3.2 Defining data governance policies

The list of all potential policies and aspects they may govern is long and never exhaustive. Trying to define and execute all of them may lead to a highly inflexible environment and is not advised. Finding the right balance between the control of the central governing body and the autonomy of data product owners is not an easy feat. Chapter 6 covers this topic, and there is still more to this art than that!

However, focusing on just the technical aspects of the data mesh and leaving data governance policies out of the MVP would be a mistake, as would be treating them offhandedly. We touched on this topic in this section's introduction. We have seen data mesh projects losing momentum because the data governance team was composed of people not capable of making policy-level decisions. Their influence on the organization was simply too limited to turn an MVP success into a company-wide commitment.

On the other hand, if you invite senior management to participate, you shouldn't expect them to spend their time deciding minor details. Make sure that the meeting agenda focuses on problems requiring policy-level solutions. Setting this expectation will enable the worthwhile engagement of senior nontechnical staff.

TIP Pick your battles wisely! The role of the MVP governance team is not to create a parallel universe but to shape business processes in a way that ensures the company is moving toward its goals. Trying to fill the gaps in the existing governance structure will create less friction than fighting the inertia of existing solutions.

In your discussion with the Messflix data governance team, you decide on an overarching policy that the data introduced to the data mesh will be FAIR.